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The Aggregator Layer: How Third-Party Databases Quietly Feed AI What It Knows About You

By Scott Tischler · October 21, 2026 · 8 min read

Most of what an AI model "knows" about your business didn't come from your website. It came from a layer of third-party databases, directories, and data providers that quietly describe you to the rest of the internet — and to the models. If that layer has you wrong, thin, or missing, the AI inherits those gaps no matter how good your own pages are. Fixing the aggregator layer is some of the highest-leverage, least-glamorous work in AI visibility.

When I audit how ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, or Google's AI describes a company, I almost never find the problem on their own site. The site is usually fine. The problem lives upstream — in the industry database that lists them in the wrong category, the review aggregator that shows four reviews from 2021, the business directory that still has the old address, the professional database where the founder's bio is three jobs out of date. The model stitches those fragments together, and the business wonders why the answer feels like a description of a company that no longer exists.

What the aggregator layer actually is

Think of it as the middle tier between you and the model. At the bottom is what you publish — your site, your profiles, your content. At the top is the AI answer a customer sees. In between sits a large, mostly invisible set of sources that collect, structure, and re-publish facts about businesses and people at scale. Business directories and local listings. Industry-specific databases and association registries. Review and reputation aggregators. Company-data providers that catalog firms, funding, and leadership. Knowledge bases and reference sites. Data brokers that quietly resell all of the above.

These sources matter to AI for a reason that's easy to miss: they're *structured* and they're *corroborating*. A model trying to resolve who you are and whether to trust you doesn't just want your own claim about yourself — it wants independent sources that say the same thing. The aggregator layer is where a lot of that independent corroboration lives. When five neutral databases agree on your

name, category, location, and what you do, that agreement reads as fact. When they disagree, or when only your own site makes the claim, the model hedges.

My read, and it's a read rather than a guarantee, is that this layer is disproportionately influential precisely because it's machine-readable and treated as reference material. A messy blog post is hard for a model to extract cleanly. A clean database record is not. The layer punches above its weight.

It helps to be concrete about what's actually in this tier, because "directories" undersells it. There are the general business listings and map data that feed local answers. There are the industry-specific databases and professional registries that define who's a legitimate player in a field. There are review and reputation aggregators that carry your ratings and the language customers use about you. There are company-intelligence providers that catalog firms, funding, headcount, and leadership for a business audience. There are reference and knowledge bases that models treat as near-authoritative. And underneath all of it, data brokers quietly collect, merge, and resell records across the whole set. A customer never visits most of these. The model, in effect, already has.

Why your own site can't carry the whole load

Businesses pour effort into their website and assume that's the job done. It's necessary, but it's not sufficient, and here's the uncomfortable logic: your own site is the one source a model knows is self-interested. Of course you say you're the best option in your category. Everyone's site says that. The model discounts self-description and reaches for corroboration — and corroboration, by definition, isn't on your site.

So you can have a flawless homepage and still get described poorly, because the independent layer the model leans on for verification is telling a different, older, or thinner story. I've watched businesses rewrite their site four times trying to fix an AI answer that was never going to move, because the signal dragging the answer down lived in a directory they'd forgotten they were listed in.

This is also why the aggregator layer is a quiet failure mode. Nothing alerts you. There's no dashboard that says "an industry database has your category wrong and it's costing you." You just get vague or mistaken AI answers and assume it's a content problem on your end, when it's really a data-hygiene problem one tier up.

How to work the layer in your favor

- **Find out where you already exist.** Before you add anything, map what's out there. Search your business and founder names and see which directories, databases, and aggregators already carry a record. You're almost always in more places than you think, and some of those records predate your current reality.

- **Fix the records you can claim.** Many of these sources let you claim and correct your listing. The highest-value move is making the facts consistent and current everywhere — the same name, the same category, the same location, the same core description. Inconsistency across the layer is what gives the model permission to hedge or to split you into two half-entities.
- **Prioritize the structured, high-trust sources.** Not every directory matters. The ones worth your time are the structured, widely-referenced, category-defining databases in your field — the places a careful human researcher would check, because those are the places a model treats as reference. A thousand spammy directory listings do nothing; three authoritative, accurate records do a lot.
- **Get your category and relationships right, not just your name.** The layer doesn't only tell the model you exist. It tells the model what *kind* of thing you are and what you're connected to. A wrong category is worse than a missing one — it files you into the wrong consideration set entirely. Make sure the structured facts place you correctly.
- **Keep it current, because the layer decays.** Addresses change, leadership changes, offerings change. These records don't update themselves, and a stale record is a slow leak. Treat the aggregator layer like a garden you weed a couple of times a year, not a thing you set once.

How to tell if the layer is your problem

Here's a simple diagnostic I use before touching anything. Ask the major AI engines to describe your business plainly — what you do, where you are, what category you're in — and read the answer like a stranger would. Then compare it against what's true. If the answer is wrong in a specific, factual way (wrong location, wrong category, a service you dropped years ago, a detail you've never put on your own site), that's a strong tell that the error is coming from the aggregator layer rather than your content. Your site doesn't say the wrong thing; something upstream does, and the model picked it up.

The other tell is divergence. If different AI engines describe you differently — one gets your category right, another gets it wrong, a third hedges — that usually means the underlying sources disagree with each other. Consistent, corroborated facts produce consistent answers across engines. When the answers scatter, the data behind them is scattered too, and the fix is to make the independent sources agree rather than to rewrite a page the model was never reading for those facts in the first place.

The honest limits

Let me be straight about what this won't do. Cleaning up the aggregator layer is table stakes, not a growth strategy. It removes drag and prevents misattribution; it doesn't by itself make you the recommended answer. If the underlying reality is thin — no real authority, no reason for anyone to cite you — getting your directory records tidy just means the model has accurate information about an

entity it still has no strong reason to recommend. Data hygiene makes your real signals legible. It doesn't manufacture signals that aren't there.

There's also a part of this layer you simply don't control. Data brokers and third-party databases will hold records about you that you can't claim or edit, and some of them will be wrong. You can't scrub the entire middle tier. What you can do is make the high-trust, claimable, widely-referenced sources accurate and consistent, so that the weight of evidence tips toward the correct version of you — and the stray wrong record becomes the outlier the model discounts rather than the fact it repeats.

If AI is describing your business in a way that feels off — outdated, miscategorized, vaguely wrong in a way you can't trace to any one page — don't start by rewriting your homepage again. Start one tier up. Find out what the aggregator layer is saying about you, fix what you can claim, and make the structured facts tell one consistent, current story. It's unglamorous work, but it's the ground the rest of your AI visibility stands on.

Key takeaways

- Most of what AI “knows” about you comes from a middle layer of third-party databases and directories, not from your own website.
- That layer matters because it’s structured and independent — it gives the model the corroboration it won’t take from your self-interested site.
- A flawless homepage can’t fix a bad AI answer if the signal dragging it down lives in a stale directory or database record.
- It’s a quiet failure: no alert tells you a record is wrong, so businesses blame their content when it’s really a data-hygiene problem one tier up.
- Map where you exist, claim and correct the records you can, prioritize structured high-trust sources, get your category right, and keep it current.
- Honest limit: cleaning the layer removes drag and prevents misattribution — it doesn’t manufacture authority you haven’t earned.

Frequently asked questions

Which directories and databases actually matter for AI visibility?

The structured, widely-referenced, category-defining ones in your field — the places a careful researcher would check, because those are the places a model treats as reference. A thousand spammy listings do nothing; a few

authoritative, accurate records do a lot. Prioritize the ones you can claim and that already appear when you search your own name.

I fixed my website but AI still describes my business wrong. Why?

Because the signal dragging the answer down almost always lives upstream, not on your site. The model discounts self-description and reaches for independent corroboration, which lives in third-party databases and directories. If those are stale or miscategorized, the AI inherits that — no matter how good your own pages are. Start one tier up from your website.

Can I control everything in the aggregator layer?

No, and it’s worth being honest about that. Data brokers and some third-party databases hold records you can’t claim or edit, and a few will be wrong. You can’t scrub the whole middle tier. The realistic goal is to make the high-trust, claimable, widely-referenced sources accurate and consistent so the weight of evidence tips toward the correct version of you, and the stray wrong record becomes the outlier the model discounts.

About the author. Scott Tischler is the Founder & Chairman of AIrecommend.ai and a practitioner-authority on AI search and Answer Engine Optimization. With 20+ years in marketing technology — including American Express, MetLife, and UBS — and executive and professional study at Wharton, Harvard, and Oxford, he helps businesses become the ones AI recommends.

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